

C9 Conflict and Tone Communication

Major rebuild. Absorbs C5 (Role-Play Challenge), C7 (Emotional Tone Management), and V6 (Navigating Constructive Conflict). This is now the single worksheet for all conflict-related communication skills.

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	55-65 minutes	Group Size	4-10 (optimal: 6-8)
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person preferred
Prerequisites	V1 (Vulnerability Circle) and C2 (Listening Circle) strongly recommended	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Conflict avoidance, emotional tone misinterpretation, varying communication styles causing friction, poor feedback reception, managing conflict signals

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Conflict triggers the amygdala's fight-or-flight response. Within milliseconds of perceiving a disagreement as a threat, cortisol floods the prefrontal cortex, shutting down the brain's capacity for rational thought, empathy, and creative problem-solving. This is the 'amygdala hijack' that makes people say things they regret, shut down entirely, or escalate when de-escalation is what's needed.

Tone is the primary trigger. The brain processes tone of voice before content. Neuroscience research shows that the emotional centre of the brain evaluates whether a message is safe or threatening based on tone in approximately 200 milliseconds, long before the prefrontal cortex has processed the actual words. This is why the same feedback delivered in a calm tone lands differently than the same words delivered with frustration.

Conflict communication skills are trainable. The brain can learn to recognise the early signs of an amygdala hijack (increased heart rate, flushed face, tunnel vision) and use deliberate pause techniques to allow the prefrontal cortex to re-engage. This exercise teaches both the recognition and the intervention.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"Every team has disagreements. The question is whether we handle them in a way that makes the team stronger or in a way that leaves damage behind. Most of us were never taught how to disagree constructively, so we either avoid conflict entirely or handle it badly. This exercise gives us the skills to do it well."

Before You Begin

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

Do NOT run this exercise if:

- There is an active, unresolved conflict between specific team members (this exercise teaches skills, it does not resolve existing disputes)
- The team has not done any vulnerability or trust-building work (V1 or equivalent)
- The manager is one of the parties in an unresolved conflict with a team member

If an active conflict exists, address it through direct conversation or mediation first. Then use this exercise to build the skills that prevent future conflicts from festering.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Amygdala Hijack (8 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"When someone disagrees with us, or delivers a message in a tone we don't like, our brain treats it as a threat. The amygdala, our brain's alarm system, fires before we've even processed the words. Heart rate increases. We get tunnel vision. We prepare to fight back or shut down. This is called an amygdala hijack, and it happens to everyone."

"The skill we're going to practise today is catching that hijack before it takes over. Recognising the physical signs, pausing, and choosing how to respond rather than reacting on autopilot."

Ask: "Think about your last disagreement or tense conversation at work. What happened in your body? Did your heart rate go up? Did you feel heat? Did your chest tighten? Did you go quiet?" These physical signs are the early warning system.

Phase 2: Tone Awareness (10 minutes)

Absorbed from C7. This phase builds awareness of how tone shapes message reception.

Present a single neutral statement: "The deadline has been moved forward by a week." Ask one volunteer to deliver this statement in four different tones:

- Matter-of-fact (neutral)
- Frustrated ("Can you believe this?")
- Apologetic ("I'm sorry but...")
- Accusatory ("Because somebody didn't plan properly...")

WHAT TO SAY

"Same words. Completely different messages. When you're on the receiving end, which tone makes you defensive? Which makes you want to collaborate? Your brain decided how to respond before it finished processing the sentence. That's tone doing its work."

Phase 3: The Pause Protocol (10 minutes)

Teach a specific, practisable technique for interrupting the amygdala hijack:

1. Notice: recognise the physical signs (heart rate, tension, heat)
2. Name: internally label what's happening ("I'm having a stress response")
3. Pause: take one deliberate breath before responding (3-4 seconds is enough)
4. Choose: ask yourself "What response will move this forward?" rather than "How do I win/defend/escape?"

FACILITATION NOTE

The naming step is backed by neuroscience research. Labelling an emotion ("I'm frustrated") activates the prefrontal cortex and reduces amygdala activity. This is called 'affect labelling' and it measurably reduces the intensity of the emotional response.

Phase 4: Scenario Practice (20 minutes)

Absorbed from C5. Divide into pairs. Provide two pre-prepared scenarios relevant to the team's actual work (not generic workplace examples). Each pair practises both roles.

Scenario structure:

- Person A delivers a message with a challenging tone (frustrated, dismissive, or urgent)
- Person B practises the Pause Protocol: notices their reaction, names it silently, pauses, then responds with one of these frames:

RESPONSE FRAMES

Acknowledge before responding: "I can hear this is urgent. Let me make sure I understand the issue."

Name the impact without blame: "When the message comes with that level of urgency, it's harder for me to think clearly about the solution."

Redirect to content: "I want to address the substance of this. Can we separate the deadline question from the frustration about how we got here?"

After each practice round, brief debrief in pairs: "What happened in your body? Were you able to pause? What did you notice about the response frames?"

Phase 5: Team Agreements (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Based on what we've practised, what agreements can we make about how we'll handle tense moments going forward? I'll start: I commit to pausing before I respond when I notice I'm reacting to tone rather than content. What would you commit to?"

Capture 2-3 team agreements. Keep them specific and actionable. "We'll be respectful" is not an agreement. "When we notice we're reacting to tone, we'll name it: 'I think we might be in amygdala territory'" is an agreement.

Phase 6: Close (2 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Conflict isn't the problem. How we handle it is. The skills we practised today won't feel natural the first time you use them in a real situation. That's fine. The fact that you pause at all, even for a second, is the change. One second between reaction and response is the difference between escalation and resolution."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A scenario practice becomes a real argument between the pair	Intervene immediately: "Let's pause the scenario. It looks like this touched something real. That's actually valuable, it means the practice is close to reality. Let's step out of the roles and talk about what just happened." If needed, take a break.
Someone says they never have conflict (avoidance disguised as harmony)	Gently challenge: "Conflict doesn't always look like an argument. It can look like quietly disagreeing but going along, or doing things differently than agreed because you think the decision was wrong, or avoiding a conversation you know you need to have. Does any of that resonate?"
The pause protocol feels artificial	"It is artificial right now. So was learning to drive. The goal is to practise it enough that the pause becomes automatic. You don't need to announce 'I'm doing the pause protocol.' You just need the one breath."
Team members resist the idea that they have amygdala hijacks	"Everyone does. The question is not whether it happens but whether you notice when it's happening. The best conflict communicators aren't people who don't get triggered. They're people who catch the trigger before it controls their response."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Visible self-recognition during the amygdala hijack discussion ("Oh, that's

	what happens to me") Practice rounds improve noticeably between first and second attempts Team agreements feel personal and genuine, not generic
Within 2-4 weeks	Someone uses the pause in a real situation and references it afterward A tense conversation de-escalates faster than it would have previously Someone uses shared language: "I think we're in amygdala territory"
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Communication scores improve Conflict-related signals decrease Qualitative data references managing tone, pausing, or handling disagreement differently
Red flags	If conflict avoidance increases rather than decreasing, the exercise may have made people more self-conscious about conflict without giving them confidence to engage. Schedule a follow-up practice session.

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Tone demonstration	Works well on video. The tone exercise is actually more impactful online because it isolates the voice from body language, showing how much tone carries on its own.
Scenario practice	Use breakout rooms for pairs. Bring everyone back for the debrief. The manager should visit each breakout room briefly to check energy levels.
Physical awareness	Guide participants to notice physical reactions even though you can't see them: "Put a hand on your chest for a moment. Is your heart rate elevated?" Self-monitoring works remotely.
Timing	Add 10 minutes. Transitions between breakout rooms add overhead.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	Trust is the foundation for honest conflict. Without V1's trust-building, C9's skills practice stays performative.	Run V1 before C9
C2: Listening Circle	Active listening is the primary de-escalation skill. C2 teaches it; C9 applies it under pressure.	Run C2 before C9
V10: Respectful Disagreement	V10 normalises disagreement proactively. C9 handles it when disagreement becomes tense or emotionally charged.	V10 is preventive; C9 is responsive
V3:	Feedback delivery uses the same tone	Run C9 before V3

Structured Feedback	awareness and pause skills. C9 teaches the foundation; V3 applies it to feedback specifically.	
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